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Quality control

The primary goal of complying to standards such as ISO, Six Sigma and TL is to ensure a minimum quality level (the best) and increase efficiency and productivity

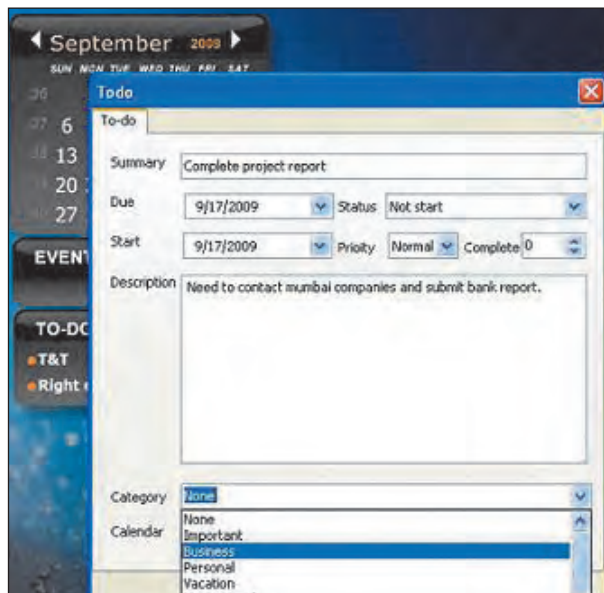
Again, turn to our Tips and tricks section for Evernote. It's a note taking software. You can take notes and use it as a post-it software. This is an efficient way of remembering tasks. Google, it is believed, uses scribble boards to jot down ideas that are randomly generated. You never know the moment when you get the answer to your question/problem. As soon as you get an idea – note it down. The best place to start could be Tasks in Gmail. If you don't use Gmail, simply save it a draft in your mailbox or a note on your mobile phone. You can delete it anytime you have finished the task.

Acting wise

After you have overcome your organising weaknesses, overcoming your performance dampeners is very important. Distractions such as IM, YouTube or even flash games (during professional hours) not only are unprofessional, but also hamper your productivity. Eventually, without realising you'd be spending some extra hours trying to get the same task done when you could have completed those eons ago. Abstinence and self control is the only way out of this.

Learn from mistakes

Once you've worked on your scheduling and straightened out your distractions, and still find it difficult to meet your targets, then you need to harness your skills and learn better ways of completing your work. It's never late to improve. You can never be too old to learn. Improve your skill sets. If you're one of those Office-suite users, you could probably fill in one an Excel sheet in a jiffy. But, on second thoughts tons of typing could be done away with a macro. Nifty two-minute tricks can save you hours of monotonous work. Depending on your profession, your tasks and tools could vary; but the never-say-die attitude will always keep you going. Albert Einstein has summed it up aptly: "You never fail until you stop trying." In fact, a task as prioritising lies



A simple tool such as a calendar, and a conscious effort to track your time will certainly increase your productivity

in the attitude rather than the available tools. For instance, email clients such as Outlook let you flag your emails – red as being critical coming down to green and even no flag as being least on priority.

MANAGING YOUR DAY

Planning your typical day, the previous night, will take you a long way. If you wake up at around 7 am every morning, you can start off by identifying your "peak productivity" hours and also your slog overs. Your first hour, 7-8 am, would be spent in getting ready – up from your bed till you're ready to start your journey. Jot down all your tasks sequentially. Surprises and spoilers will erupt and these are unavoidable. So get your list in the order of priority; from highest to lowest. Lunch time is not productive at all – add to that half an hour before and a couple of hours later when the answer to most troubles is 40 winks.

Attempting critical tasks during these hours most certainly involves reorganising and reworking, thereby reducing overall efficiency. You can lift up yourself by attempting lesser critical tasks such as

personal email. You can also plan any pending official tasks you may have. The options are endless. Again, as the end of day approaches, rush hour work increases. All those daily reports need to go out and several people need to be reminded of tasks left unattended. You should wrap up as many critical tasks as you have by now. This is your 11th hour for all practical purposes. Depending on how longer your list gets, waking up tomorrow morning is going to be more aggravating. Any remedies? On advantage if you use public transport is using your mobile phone to jot down unattended tasks. Irrespective of what you own, whether you jot them down on a piece of paper, or access Google calendar from your GPRS-enabled mobile phone – a record must be maintained and reminders need to be set.

Freedom at last

Some lessons are learnt the hard way. Criticism and feedback are part of every organisation. Learning early is evidence of wisdom. There's no running away from this. Seldom will you get praise for a job well done. But mess up once and it'll continue to haunt you for a long while. Failures are stepping stones to success. Believe in what you do and you will soon be avoiding hurdles that are higher than your leap. As an old Ethiopian saying goes, "Do not vacillate or you will be left in between doing something, having something and being nothing." No one's perfect. We're all improving. Just go ahead, reach out. Now you know how others could leave early when you felt you were slogging alone. No one can stop you either. Remember the story we learned as kids. The hare slept. The tortoise although slow, achieved its goal because it persisted. 

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